

current market. What's in it for them? The listing, and your business, when you opt to sell.

- If your budget is especially tight, consider a community working bee in exchange for an appropriate donation. Approach local sports clubs and ask if they have members and families who are handy with tools, precise with a paintbrush and not shy about putting a shoulder to the wheel. In a footy team, there are bound to be some tradies. A cash gift of \$10,000–\$15,000 to that club for a weekend of basic labouring to paint inside and out, weed, change doors, lights and tap fittings, and move furniture is a win-win for all.
- There are plenty of online resources to turn a rookie renovator into a confident, tool-belt-wielding future contestant on *The Block*, as well as lots of private courses, clubs and mentoring. Many are targeted at investor renovators who want to learn to 'flip' homes for profit; that is, purchasing, updating and selling, in a short timeframe, to make money. With that in mind, I recommend your state's TAFE institutions – you would be surprised how many have hands-on basic home maintenance and improvement evening classes and short courses for everyday novices.

If you are considering flipping a home, you'd be wise to note the following:

- **Set personal taste aside**

A neutral colour scheme, easy-to-maintain features and avoiding interior decorating trends is your *modus operandi*, not just because this is more economical for you, but to capture broad market appeal. You might love rose-gold taps and feature tiles in the bathroom, but a buyer could walk in and want to barf in the Moroccan-patterned sink. The same goes for wall paint colours – make it a blank but beautiful canvas.

- **Change in circumstances**

If your budget blows out, interest rates rise, you cannot complete the renovation or you struggle to sell, you need to understand the bigger picture and its impact on your bank balance. Speak to a financial planner or advisor to unpick the worst-case scenarios, and whether you have enough to survive this sort of hiccup.